

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

pened seven years ago. The athletes did not go to the police station to file a complaint but to Jantar Mantar instead. I cancelled the trip I was on, and I met them for several hours. It is a sensitive issue, and we gave them a patient hearing, as well as took the right steps as per their demand to form the (Mary Kom) committee. The committee was very open and listened to each one it met. On the one hand, the committee can't rush its report without listening to everyone as many of these incidents happened seven years ago, and on the other, the Delhi Police are investigating and they will take the time they need.

Q. Why wasn't the Mary Kom panel report made public?

It is a sensitive issue and we have nothing to hide. The only issue is that when further investigation is required at the police level, it wouldn't be fair to make it public. Let it be the property of the court to decide on the matter after the police have investigated it.

Q. The other accusation is that because Singh is a BJP MP, the Modi government is trying to protect him. What do you have to say?

This is a very unfair criticism. We don't need to protect anyone; the law is taking its own course. The committee has looked into the matter; the police are investigating it too and are going to file the chargesheet by June 15. Look at the Supreme Court order—it said the Delhi Police has filed an FIR and told the petitioners to reach out to the local magistrate if they have any such issues to be taken up at that level. And let me put it on record, we are very clear that a transparent probe in a timely manner should be completed, and the chargesheet should be filed. Let court decide the further course of action.

Q. You had a long conversation with the athletes recently. What were their demands and your response?

They had some demands. They wanted the chargesheet to be filed by the 15th; we agreed. They wanted the wrestling federation election to be held at the earliest; we said okay, it needs 21 days to be held and we will try and do it by June 30. They wanted security cover for them; we said, yes, the government can look into that. They said the Internal Complaints Committee (ICC) should be formed, and we said, yes, it should be done on priority. They wanted the cases against them to be withdrawn; we said, yes, we can look into that. They said that the wrestlers should be consulted on the formation of the new body, and we said whosoever is contesting, they can engage with them, and their views could be taken on that. So, we are very open to all kinds of suggestions.

Q. What about their demand that the MP concerned should not contest this time?

He will not contest because his 12-year-term limit is already over, and he is ineligible to do so.

Q. The WFI didn't have an ICC. What about other sporting federations?

Even the wrestling federation had one. As per their record, Sakshi was heading it. We have told all federations that they should have the ICC in place—most of them had one and the others are following suit.

Q. What are the lessons from the entire episode given that women are now competing in various sports in much bigger numbers than before?

One, it shouldn't happen. Two, they should be aware of their rights and report such incidents as soon as they take place without any fear.